

Tail-piece

It is the age-old experience and wisdom of our elderly people that counts much. You got to know it from the story "A Wise Grandmother". Let's read another story and see what it tells.

The Text

THE LAND WITHOUT OLD MEN

Long long ago, in one cold country, all the young people decided to kill all the old people. What was the use of their going on living with their white beard and all? They had had their life, they had had their time, and that was that.

"But we need them", said a man who was not very old and not very young.

But the king was young. So giving the order did not trouble him. He declared that anyone who had reached the age of fifty was to be killed. Thus lots of wise old men were killed and lots of wisdom passed away with them.

Only one kind-hearted young man took pity on his old father. After all, he owed his life to his father. So, he hid him away in an underground room and took care of him.

Time passed and a terrible drought came. The young people tried to put up with all kinds of troubles, but more and more troubles followed. The snow melted and spring came. But they did not have a single grain of seed to put in the ground.

The old man in the cellar could see that his son was going about looking very unhappy all the time. One day he asked him, "Are you in trouble, my son? Tell your father all about it. He may be able to help you".



The son told him all about the troubles, from beginning to end. The old man thought for a while, and then said, "Don't tell anybody anything now. But when the last patches of snow melt on the fields, take your plough and plough up the lane in front of your house".

When the spring came and the snow melted, the son did as his old father had told him. And what did he see? There came a quick spring rain, and out of the ground there began to grow wheat and maize, oats and barley, and even beans and peas in some places.

It seemed so wonderful that the news of it spread up and down the country. It was a thing no one had ever heard of a man's growing crops without putting seeds in the ground.

The king got to hear of it too. He quickly ordered the boy to be brought before him.

"What did you do? How did you do it?", the king started asking him questions at once. In fear, the boy told the truth.

"Bring me your father here," the king ordered. So the old man was brought before the king.

"What made you think there would be seeds in the doorway?"

"Well, Your Majesty, just think of how many seeds drop on the ground when people carry the corn home on their carts."

The wise old man was given a royal reward. He had saved the life of the whole nation.

And ever since then, they have respected all old people.

Word Note

- ashes : the powder that remains after a human body (something) is burnt, ପାଉଁଶ
- attachment : a feeling of love or strong liking for someone or something, ଗଭୀର ସଂପର୍କ
- courtyard : an open space inside or in front of a large house, ଅଗଣା
- creased : made lines by folding skin on forehead, କୁଞ୍ଚିତ, ଲୋଡ଼ାକୋଡ଼ା
- crooked : bent, ବଙ୍କା
- curved : bent round, ବୃତ୍ତ ପରି ବଙ୍କା

drought	: a long period of time when there is little or no rain, ମରୁଡ଼ି, ଅନାବୃଷ୍ଟି
farewell (opposite-welcome)	: saying goodbye, ବିଦାୟ
forehead	: the part of the face above the eyes and below the hair, କପାଳ
improve	: to become better than before, ଉନ୍ନତି କରିବା
promise	: to tell someone that you will definitely do or not do (something), ପ୍ରତିଜ୍ଞା କରିବା
remorse	: a felling of guilty, ଅନୁରାଗ
riddle	: puzzle, a question that is difficult to understand, and that has a surprising answer, ଗୋଲକ ଧନ୍ଦା
scarce	: hard or difficult to find, not easily available, ଦୁର୍ଲ୍ଲଭ
thread	: a long thin piece of cotton, wool, silk etc. used for sewing, ସୂତା
threaten	: to tell someone that you will kill or hurt or trouble etc, ଧମକ ଦେବା
thrilled	: very excited and pleased, very much happy, ଉଲ୍ଲାସିତ, ବହୁତ ଖୁସି, ଅତି ଆନନ୍ଦିତ
troubles	: problems, difficulties, worries, ଅସୁବିଧା, ସମସ୍ୟା
warlord	: a military leader who controls a particular area or a country, ମିଳିତାରୀ ଶାସକ

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melt	: to make or become a liquid by heating, ତରଳିଯିବା
pass away	: die, ମରିବା
reward (opposite - punishment)	: something given in return of good work, ପୁରସ୍କାର
royal	: relating to a king or a queen or their family, ରାଜକୀୟ
terrible	: making frightened, unpleasant, ଭୟଙ୍କର
wisdom	: the quality of being wise, ଜ୍ଞାନ